

JANICE KURRLE SOUTH AUSTRALIA EDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we are visiting South Australia. I have as our guest Janice Currie, who's the Regional Manager for UK and Europe for the South Australian Tourism Commission. And Janice, welcome to the program.

Thank you. Thank you for having me. Now Janice, South Australia is such an iconic destination for people from all over the world.

It's a foodie heaven, it's a wine heaven. For people who've never been to a South Australia, tell us a bit about the state. I think people are quite surprised when they come to South Australia because they don't quite know what to expect.

We don't have massive icons. We're also maybe tucked away. People think South Australia is the whole bottom of Australia.

But what we do have is incredible food and wine, as you mentioned, wildlife and natural landscapes. And I think for me, the most beneficial for people visiting the state is they can have a whole Australian experience in South Australia, from the ocean to the outback and the wineries in between. Adelaide itself is such a beautiful city.

From Adelaide, you can fan out and do everything. But tell us a bit about Adelaide for people who've never been. And actually, a lot of the churches are now converted into cafes and restaurants.

And I think that's the surprising thing about Adelaide. The Adelaide that people know of, maybe, you know, the 1980s is certainly not the Adelaide that we know today. What I love about Adelaide, it's built on a grid system, which means everywhere is very accessible.

It's 20 minutes to the coast in one direction and the beautiful beaches of Glenelg. And 20 minutes in the other direction to the lovely national parks and the vineyards of the Adelaide Hills. But Adelaide itself is Australia's only national park city.

Park lands are really important in the city. It's also one of 12 wine capitals of the world. You're never far away from a glass of wine in Adelaide.

But it's also about the culture. Adelaide has the largest fringe festival outside of Edinburgh. So if you're there in February and March, it's a great time to visit the city, full of lots of cheer and events throughout the period.

And food and wine is in South Australia's DNA, as you mentioned earlier. So paddock-to-plate, ocean-to-plate is really, really important, as are low food miles. And all of our chefs in Adelaide really embrace local communities and getting food straight from the source.

We have the largest undercover fresh food market in the Southern Hemisphere, for example, at Adelaide Central Market. We have laneway bars and restaurants filled with delicious restaurants of all cuisines, whether that's African cuisine or Asian fusion. Also going, you know, Afghanistan.

We have, you know, a beautiful Afghan restaurant in Adelaide. So wherever you go in Adelaide, you can be assured of very fresh local produce and delicious wines, of course, to match. Now let's touch on the wines, because South Australia is probably world-renowned for having some of the best wines on the entire planet.

And the export market for South Australian wine is huge. It is. And I think, you know, what people don't realise is that South Australia has 18 wine regions.

Who would think there's 200 cellar doors, as I mentioned earlier, within an hour's drive from Adelaide. And that's as close as the Adelaide Hills in 20 minutes, McLaren Vale in 40 minutes, the Barossa is reached in under an hour. And most people think, why would I go to a winery if I don't drink wine? Or is it just this boozy-filled bus tour? But actually we have a lot of local operators who offer winery safaris.

So you can go out in intimate groups. They will take you behind the cellar door so you get to meet a winemaker. You can have a long winery lunch at many of the vineyards.

We also have opportunities to cycle through the vineyards or even to ride horses through the vineyards. So it's not always about tasting wines. It's all about really enjoying that winery experience, but also the other activities that are available, from hot air ballooning to cooking schools, you know, the list is endless.

So I think our wineries are very much now part of the whole tourism experience in South Australia. Now, we have to mention the coastline because there's so many activities with the coast. There's fishing, there's diving.

Can you go into that for us? I can. And I think, you know, wherever people travel in Australia, there's lots and lots of coastal activities for people to take part in. From paddleboarding or swimming in the Eyre Peninsula, where you can actually swim with sea lions, which is a really lovely experience.

I've actually done that. They're called puppy dogs of the seas because they just tumble in front of you. A really, really lovely experience.

Also swimming with pods of hundreds of dolphins on the Eyre Peninsula or Kangaroo Island and cage shark diving. And I mean, I know a lot of people don't want to talk about the great white shark, but we know an iconic South Australian man from Glenelg, Rodney Fox, was a great white shark survivor and he actually vented the cage shark. So, you know, sustainability is at the heart of that particular operation.

And it's actually nice to see them undertaking research of the great white shark and the shark's habitat. There's so many aquatic adventures and it's not just about the adventures that are under the sea, but also our seafood. You know, the Eyre Peninsula is one of the great areas of the Southern Hemisphere for tuna.

We have lots of regions where you can get delicious. King George Whiting on Kangaroo Island, lobster found everywhere. And of course we love Coffin Bay oysters as well, which are a delight.

Now, speaking of the landscapes, South Australia is a magnet for filmmakers who make some of the most magnificent movies in the world. Tell us about that sort of thing. It's a big industry.

Yeah, I think we've got a lot of iconic landscapes. I go back to the size of South Australia and the fact that anyone can have a complete Australian experience in South Australia. Those lunar landscapes of Cooperpedie, where most of the population lives underground.

Their houses, they're able to just make another room as they like. But you've got this incredible Mars-like landscape of deep, rich colours on the exterior. And then the Flinders Ranges, only a five-hour drive north of Adelaide.

So for filmmakers, very, very accessible, but you've got the outback. The Flinders Ranges is actually in Lonely Planet's top 10 list this year to visit in 2026. So it's putting that region on the map.

We've got dark sky reserves, dark sky sanctuaries. For me, it's the luxury of being out in the outback and not surrounded by a hundred other people. It's that luxury of place and also space.

Well, the billion star landscape, that's a dream of many, many people to get out there at nighttime and see that. And once you get past the city lights, it is an incredible experience when you do see those billions of stars out. Totally.

And we've got a couple of these areas within South Australia. We've got the Murray River, which has a dark sky sanctuary, Arca Ruler as well, the Flinders Ranges. And I think with astro-tourism and with that growing amongst people wanting to see the northern lights or the southern lights, it offers a great opportunity for people to see those bright, starlit skies at night, which is a really magical experience.

Well, it's wonderful having you on the program, Janice Currie. Now you're based in Europe. You market South Australia and Adelaide to the whole world.

That's right. My remit is actually looking after the UK and Europe. I am Australian, as you can probably tell from the accent, but I love the diversity of South Australia, but more so it's the people of South Australia.

And I think that's what sets South Australia apart from other regions is that when you come to

South Australia, you're welcomed like a local person. And that means that if you go on a small group tour or if you have lunch in a winery, you're actually met with welcoming, open hands. It's ingrained in the people.

They find their place on the land. They'll take you underneath the depths of South Australia that you just skim as a surface and really get to know the destinations, the favourite local restaurants, but really have a great sense of belonging. And that's what's really lovely about visiting South Australia.

Well, how can people find out more about South Australia if they want to visit from overseas, Janice? We have a website, so southaustralia.com is probably the best place to try as a first stop shop. And that will list all of our regions, all of the experiences that you want to undertake, and also a calendar of events. We have Tasting Australia every year.

We have the cycling race, Tour Down Under. We have AFL Gather Round, Live Golf. There's a host of different events throughout the year, a great calendar for people to experience the destination at any time of the year that they choose.

Thank you so much, Janice Currie from the South Australian Tourist Board. Thank you very much for being on the program. Thanks for having me.

Thanks so much.